How to Fix the Mess

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ADOPT CBT FORMAT

Adopt a computer-based test (CBT) format to enhance security and reduce logistical challenges associated with NEET. While CBTs are not immune to glitches and have faced instances of hacking attempts, such issues can be mitigated by implementing newer technologies such as AI-based proctoring

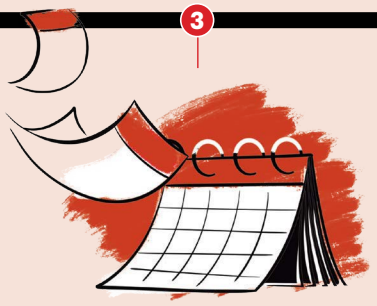
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STANDARDISE TESTS

Follow standardised tests like the US's SAT, ACT and GRE, which evaluate critical thinking over rote memorisation, reducing the advantage of extensive practice at coaching centres. NEET's question patterns are said to be inconsistent

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MULTIPLE TEST DATES

Offer multiple test dates throughout the year. This approach reduces stress by spreading the risk over a longer period. In 2018, the education ministry had planned to hold NEET twice a year but later shelved the idea

Jalaram School in Godhra, which served as the exam centre; and Tushar Bhatt, a teacher at the school who was also the designated deputy superintendent for the exam centre. Students involved in the cheating scandal would initially fill in the answers they knew, and once the answer key was released, the teachers would complete the remaining answers. The Gujarat Police found that at least 26 students from across the country paid Rs 10 lakh to Rs 66 lakh each to clear NEET.

NEET VS JEE-MAIN

A medical degree in India is considered a key to a financially secure future, as even without a job, a doctor can earn from private practice. This makes an MBBS seat more lucrative than an engineering degree, making the competition as well as the corruption more intense. It does not help that the number of medical seats is extremely limited—this year, a staggering 2.3 million students vied for just over 100,000 medical seats, of which only half are in government medical colleges. The number of engineering seats available in India, on the other hand, are more than a million, or 10 times more than medical seats. In fact, engineering seats are exceeding demand, leading to a closure of colleges. Only a high NEET score enables admission in reputed government institutions, which charge fees far lower than what private colleges demand. According to the latest India Today Best Colleges Survey, the lowest annual course fee in a government medical college is Rs 1,628 compared to Rs 1.9 lakh in a private college, minus the other unofficial charges.

Also, unlike the JEE-Main, which is a computer-based test (CBT), NEET is a pen-and-paper test, and therefore more open to vulnerabilities at the logistics end than. CBTs too are plagued by technical glitches and occasional impersonation cases, but these are generally less severe compared to the issues NEET faces. The NTA had, in fact, planned to conduct NEET as a CBT in 2018, but the health ministry objected, citing concerns about its feasibility for students in rural areas who may not have sufficient access to computers and the internet. Following the latest controversy, the education ministry has written to the health ministry to reconsider its decision. Pradhan, however, cites India's 300,000 capacity as insufficient to conduct a CBT for NEET as it will require six or so sittings for all to take the exam. The JEE, which 1.4 million students take, is conducted twice a year and is spread over 5-6 days. Even the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), Pradhan says, conducted the medical entrance exam in pen-and-paper mode, like it does the board exams.

In a CBT format, the question paper and answer keys are encrypted and saved separately. The creation of question papers is automated, utilising a vast question bank meticulously developed and categorised over time. The encrypted question paper reaches every examination centre and is decrypted only when the candidate clicks on it. Also, unlike NEET, the IIT faculty is involved in setting the questions for the JEE-Main. The JEE Apex Board (JAB), including members of the IITs and other top institutes, is the final authority on setting the policies, rules and regulations for the conduct of the JEE-Main. The NTA manages all information technology-related support and back-end activities for pre- and post-examination